FLEET TEAM DIGEST

737MAX-FTD-27-17003

Issue Title : Elevator Feel Differential Faults after De-icing

Airplane Model	ATA	Minor Model(s)
737MAX	2731-17	-7, -8, -8200, -9, -BBJ

Other Model(s)	ECCN
737NG	9E991

Originated Date	Last Revised Date	Created On
05/17/2017	05/17/2017	05/10/2017

Estimated Completion Date	Next Update Date

Description

This article is being published to advise operators of nuisance faults that can occur with the elevator feel system during cold weather conditions that require frequent deicing/anti-icing operations to the airplane.

Background

In 2011, a 737NG operator reported eight different occurrences where an airplane was pulled out of service for "Elev Feel Diff" light illuminations. The warning light illuminations occurred shortly after dispatch in extremely cold weather over a two day period. The warning light fault during airplane climbout was preceded by one or several deicing/anti-icing fluid applications. The fault cleared prior to reaching cruise in all instances.

The operator performed FIM 27-31 Task 803 to isolate the fault. In most cases the pitot lines were found to have water present during the flushing procedure. The visco restrictor drains for the pitot lines were found containing debris that may prevent the water from draining.

Status

There is no requirement to pull the airplane from service for "Elev Feel Diff" faults that clear during flight. We consider this fault as a nuisance fault and recommend operators only perform the FIM checks if the fault continues to repeat or is illuminated prior to dispatch.

We suggest operators coordinate with their deicing service provider to ensure that the deicing fluid is not sprayed directly into the pitot tubes on the vertical fin. We suggest deicing providers spray above the probes and allow the fluid to run down onto the probes to prevent direct ingress of water or de-icing fluid into the elevator feel system. It can be difficult to avoid secondary fluid spray coming off the airplane surface from reaching specific areas and therefore it is important to keep the direct fluid spray pattern a good distance away from items such as the elevator pitot probes.

AMM 12-33-01 states the following:

WARNING: DO NOT DIRECTLY SPRAY DEICING FLUIDS INTO APU OR ENGINE INLETS, EXHAUSTS, DUCTS AND PITOT-STATIC PROBES. THESE FLUIDS CAN CAUSE DAMAGE TO THE EQUIPMENT AND CAN CAUSE BAD AIR FLIGHT DATA.

Interim Action

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This article is being published to increase awareness of nuisance "Elev Feel Diff" faults during cold weather operation.

Operators should defer FIM 27-31 Task 803 if the fault clears during flight and is not present prior to dispatch. Airplanes that have repeat faults should be scheduled for maintenance at the next convenient opportunity.

Final Action

Operators should increase the frequency of pitot line flushing during the winter months if their fleet is experiencing increased occurrences of the "Elev Feel Diff Press" light faults during climb.

Deicing providers should notify crews to not spray deicing fluid directly into the pitot probes. Spraying above the probes allowing the fluid to run down over the probes will reduce the likelihood that fluid or water is entering the system and freezing which can cause blockage that triggers the fault.

Operator Action

We suggest operators periodically flush the pitot system and clean the visco restrictor drains to prevent water from accumulating in the lines. We suggest operators that operate in cold climates to increase these flushing tasks during the winter months if their airplanes are undergoing frequent deicing/anti-icing operations. We also suggest operators communicate with their deicing providers to ensure fluid and water is not sprayed directly into the pitot probes.

Reference Categories

Reference Type	Reference Number	Revision Number	Reference Date
Fault Isolation Manual (FIM)	27-31 Task 803 FEEL DIFF PRESS Light is ON		
Aircraft Maintenance Manual (AMM)	12-33-01 Cold Weather Maintenance - Servicing		

Related Categories

- Dispatch Reliability Issues : Issues that cause revenue flight delays and cancellations
- High Occurrence Maintenance Message : null

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